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State Examinations Commission

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S.90/10

The Irish Examination in the Leaving Certificate for 2012 onwards (Higher Level, Ordinary Level and Foundation Level)

Foreward

The attention of schools authorities and of teachers of Irish is directed to what follows below. This is a further clarification of the directive contained in 'The Assessment System' which is given in Circular 0020/2010 and in the revised syllabuses for Irish (Leaving Certificate: Higher Level and Ordinary Level 2010) and in Circular 0056/2010 and in the updated syllabus for Irish (Leaving Certificate: Foundation Level 2010) published by the Department of Education and Skills. The Circulars as well as copies of the syllabuses are available on the Department's website at www.education.ie.

Changes in the proportion of marks for certain aspects of the Leaving Certificate examination in Irish (Higher Level, Ordinary Level and Foundation Level) will take effect from the year 2012 onwards. These changes arise from the directive first set out in Circular 0042/2007 as published by the Department of Education and Science and they are fully in line with that directive. As a consequence of the evaluation of certain aspects of the examination, there will be a revised layout of certain parts of the examination paper.

A summary is given in **Part I** (i) below of the most important changes in the allocation of marks in the Higher Level and Ordinary Level Oral Test, in the Aural Comprehension Test and in the written papers and (ii) of the changes in the system of assessment which they entail.

As regards the changes in the Oral Test, the Aural Comprehension Test and the written paper (Composition and Reading Comprehension) at the Foundation Level, these are discussed one by one in **Part II**.

Sample papers based on the revised syllabuses will be issued in September 2011.

Patricia Anderson
Higher Executive Officer
December 2010

Part I – Higher Level and Ordinary Level

1.1 The Irish Leaving Certificate Syllabus (revised)

As regards the updated syllabuses, they are the same as those which are in effect at the Higher Level and the Ordinary Level and which have been in existence for some years now. The syllabuses have been revised and brought up to date especially with reference to terminology and range of topics. Both the teaching and the learning of Irish as well as the system of assessment at Higher Level and Ordinary Level will depend on the aims and goals of the syllabuses just as heretofore.

1.2 The Oral Test in Irish – from 2012 onwards (Leaving Certificate: Higher Level & Ordinary Level)

There will be a common Oral Test for the Higher Level and the Ordinary Level just as heretofore. The allocation of marks for the Oral Test will be increased from 150 marks (25% of the overall total of marks) to 240 marks (40% of the overall total of marks). A description of the various parts of the Oral Test, as well as the new marking scheme, is given at **1.3** below.

1.3 The duration of the Oral Test will be 15 minutes. It will consist of four parts: Reception, Poetry Reading, Description of a series of pictures, Conversation.

(a) The marks will be apportioned as follows:
Reception: 5 marks; Poetry Reading: 35 marks;
Description of a series of pictures: 80 marks; Conversation: 120 marks.

Table 1

The Oral Test		Duration (minutes)	Marks
1	Reception	1	5
2	Poetry reading	2	35
3	Description of picture series	4	80
4	Conversation	6 to 8	120
		15	**240**

(b) Personal details to be sought during the reception: five items of information – name, age, home address, date of birth, examination number.

(c) Candidates will be asked to recite or read aloud one of the *designated* five poems from the common literature course (Ordinary Level and Higher Level). This will be a test of the candidate's ability to understand the poem, and of accuracy of pronunciation and rhythm of speech. The examiner will choose the poem **and** the verses to be read. The candidate may use his/her own copy of the poem. No time will be allowed the candidate for the preparation of the subject matter during the examination. Until the contrary is announced the poems in question are: *Géibheann* (the complete poem); *Colscaradh* (the complete poem); *Mo Ghrá-sa* (*Idir Lúibíní*) (any three verses); *An tEarrach Thiar* (any two verses); *An Spailpín Fánach* (any two verses). Teachers are reminded that all verses in the above-mentioned poems are to be studied and that all verses will be taken into account in the Oral Test and in the written examination.

(d) There will be twenty A4 pages of pictures with a series of six pictures on each page. An A4 page will be chosen at random in the examination. As well as a description of the series of pictures on the chosen A4 page, it hoped that the candidate and the examiner will ask one another a small number of questions about the subject matter of the various pictures on the page. Please note that it is hoped that the candidate will be able to ask as well as to answer questions. Therefore *interaction* is expected in this part of the examination.

The different series of pictures will be made available to the schools for the first time in the first term of the fifth year, before the end of 2010. A sample of the A4 picture series may be found at the end of this document. The 2012 examination will be based on this series of pictures. Twenty new pages, with a series of pictures on each will be issued in September 2011 for the examinations in 2013. Twenty different pages will be issued each year afterwards. The subject matter of the pictures will be in line with the topics mentioned in the syllabuses.

(e) As obtains at present, the last part of the examination will be general conversation. It will begin with the immediate environment but the subject matter of the conversation will be extended depending on the the candidate's ability. 75 marks will be allotted to the Irish repertoire (the competence of the candidate to demonstrate the range and extent of his/her vocabulary), 45 marks will be allotted to Ability in Irish (fluency and accuracy in Irish). Therefore *interaction* is expected in this part of the examination.

1.4 The Marking of the Oral Test

(a) **Reception**: 5 marks for 5 items of information.

(b) **Poetry Recitation**: 35 marks
Top Third: The candidate's effort in the range **very good** to **excellent** in terms of rhythm and pronunciation and comprehensibility - an appropriate mark between 24 and 35.
Middle Third: The candidate's effort in the range **fair** to **good** in terms of rhythm and pronunciation and comprehensibility - an appropriate mark between 14 and 23.
Bottom Third: The candidate's effort in the range **very weak** to **weak** in terms of rhythm and pronunciation and comprehensibility – an appropriate mark between 0 and 13.

Table 2

Grade	Class	Mark
A	Excellent	29-35
B	Very Good	24-28
C	Good	19-23
D	Fair	14-18
E	Weak	9-13
F	Very Weak	0-8

(c) Description of a series of pictures: 80 marks

Top Third: The candidate's effort in the range **very good** to **excellent** in terms of giving a description of the series of pictures and displaying a mastery in asking and in answering questions and expressing opinions - an appropriate mark between 56 and 80.

Middle Third: The candidate's effort in the range **fair** to **good** in terms of giving a description of the series of pictures and displaying a mastery in asking and in answering questions and expressing opinions - an appropriate mark between 32 and 55.

Bottom Third: The candidate's effort in the range **very weak** to **weak** with a short, weak undeveloped description, a breakdown in communication, limited ability - an appropriate mark between 0 and 31.

Table 3		
Grade	**Class**	**Mark**
A	Excellent	68-80
B	Very Good	56-67
C	Good	44-55
D	Fair	32-43
E	Weak	20-31
F	Very Weak	0-19

(d) General Conversation

75 marks for Irish Repertoire; 45 marks for Language Ability. Marking as at present: 6 classes in the two categories: A – excellent; B – very good; C – good; D – fair; E – weak; F – very weak.

Table 4			
Grade	**Class**	**Irish Repertoire**	**Ability**
A	Excellent	64-75	39-45
B	Very Good	53-63	32-38
C	Good	42-52	25-31
D	Fair	30-41	18-24
E	Weak	19-29	12-17
F	Very Weak	0-18	0-11

2.1 The Aural Comprehension Test – Higher Level and Ordinary Level

As a result of the reduction in the proportion of marks allotted to the Aural Comprehension Test and of the consequent reduction in time, and for the efficient conduct of the examinations, the Aural Comprehension Test will be integrated into the written examination Paper I (Higher Level and Ordinary Level) from 2012 onwards. Paper I will begin with the Aural Comprehension Test and the rest of Paper I will continue without any interruption. This represents a change from the Aural Comprehension Test being an independent unit of the examination, as obtained heretofore.

In the case of Higher Level the proportion of marks which may be gained on the Aural Comprehension Test will be reduced from 100 marks (16.66% of the overall total of marks) to 60 marks (10% of the overall total of marks). The duration of this test will be twenty minutes.

In the case of Ordinary Level the proportion of marks which may be gained on the Aural Comprehension Test will be reduced from 120 marks (20% of the overall total of marks) to 60 marks (10% of the overall total of marks). The duration of this test will be twenty minutes also.

In the Aural Comprehension Test, each item will be played **twice**. It will consist of two announcements, two conversations and two items of news, and the three major dialects will be catered for. Both the subject matter and the questions will follow the same lines as the test which has existed for some years. The same sound recording will be played for both the Higher Level and the Ordinary Level. The questions asked will pose different challenges at Higher Level and at Ordinary Level.

3.1 The Written Papers – Leaving Certificate: Higher Level

(a) **Paper I:** 2 hours 20 minutes
Aural Comprehension Test (20 minutes)

Written Composition (2 hours)
The same subject choices will be available as were available in recent years. The same marking scheme will apply. A description of the marking scheme is available on the website of the State Examinations Commission www.examinations.ie, under the heading 'Cartlann d'Ábhar Scrúduithe/Examinations Archive Material'. The schemes for the years from 2001 to date are available.

Table 5			
The Leaving Certificate: Higher Level – Paper I			
		Time	Marks
1	Aural Comprehension Test	0-20	60
2	Written composition	2-00	100
		2-20	**160**

(b) **Paper 2:** 3 hours 5 minutes

Reading Comprehension
(50 marks and 50 marks). It will consist of two extracts of Reading Comprehension, with a question or questions based on each paragraph. The extracts for reading comprehension will follow the same lines as in recent years in terms of their length and difficulty of language. This question will consist of tests of reading comprehension but one might expect a subquestion on accuracy of language based on the text, as for example, '*Aimsigh sampla den Tuiseal Ginideach Uatha in alt a trí*'.

One question at least will look for deep understanding of the extract, as, for example:

'*Déan cur síos i d'fhocail féin ar an saghas duine é an príomhcharachtar atá luaite sa sliocht, dar leat. Ní gá níos mó ná cúig abairt a scríobh sa chuntas seo*'; **nó**

'*Ón léamh atá déanta agat ar an sliocht thuas (a) déan cur síos ar chineál an phíosa scríbhneoireachta atá ann, agus (b) abair céard iad na comharthaí sóirt a bhíonn ag an gcineál sin saothair – bíodh tagairt agat don sliocht mar thaca le do fhreagra agat.*'

Prose
Common Designated Prose (30 marks) ***or*** Prose: Optional Subject Matter (30 marks). A question or questions to be answered on one extract. No choice will be offered in the questions.

Poetry
Common Designated Poetry (30 marks) ***or*** Poetry: Optional Subject Matter (30 marks). A question or questions to be answered on one poem. No choice will be offered in the questions.

Additional Literature
(40 marks). The candidate will have a choice of two sections, the Additional Prose or the Additional Poems.

Should the candidate choose Additional Prose, there will be one question to answer on one of the five prose extracts. One question on each of the five prose extracts will appear on the examination paper.

Should the candidate choose the Additional Poems, one question will have to be answered on one poem of the five extra poems. The text of that poem will be given on the examination paper. Only one question will appear on the examination paper.

In the case of the question on the Additional Literature, only one designated work will be taken into account. No optional subject matter may be used. A subquestion may be asked in this question on the life and work of the authors. It will be expected that candidates will demonstrate an understanding of the works in the context of the history of literature in Irish.

Table 6			
The Leaving Certificate: Higher Level – Paper 2			
		Time	Marks
1	Reading Comprehension 1 (50 marks) and Reading Comprehension 2 (50 marks)	at the candidate's choice	100
2	Literature: Prose 1 (30 marks) Poetry 1 (30 marks) Additional Literature: Additional Prose ***or*** Additional Poems (40 marks)	at the candidate's choice	100
		3 – 05	**200**

3.2 The Written Papers – The Leaving Certificate: Ordinary Level

(a) **Paper I:** 1 hour 50 minutes

Aural Comprehension Test (20 minutes)

Written Composition (1 hour 30 minutes)
The same subject choices will be available as were available in recent years. The same marking scheme will apply. A description of the marking scheme is available on the website of the State Examinations Commission www.examinations.ie, under the heading 'Cartlann d'Ábhar Scrúduithe/Examinations Archive Material'. The schemes for the years from 2001 to date are available.

Table 7			
The Leaving Certificate: Ordinary Level – Paper I			
		Time	Marks
1	Aural Comprehension Test	0-20	60
2	Written composition	1-30	100
		1-50	**160**

(b) **Paper 2:** 2 hours 20 minutes
Two Reading Comprehension extracts will appear, which will be in line for the most part with what appeared on previous examination papers. Each of them will carry 50 marks. There will be two questions on the Prose (Common Designated Prose ***or*** Prose: Optional Subject Matter) at 25 marks each – 50 marks overall – and the two questions on the Poetry (Common Designated Poetry ***or*** Poetry: Optional Subject Matter) at 25 marks each – 50 marks overall. No choice will be offered in the prose or the poetry questions.

Table 8			
The Leaving Certificate: Ordinary Level – Paper 2			
		Time	Marks
1	Reading Comprehension 1 (50 marks) Reading Comprehension 2 (50 marks)	at the candidate's choice	100
2	Literature: Prose 1 (25 marks) Prose 2 (25 marks) Poetry 1 (25 marks) Poetry 2 (25 marks)	at the candidate's choice	100
		2 – 20	**200**

Part II – The Leaving Certificate: Foundation Level

4.1 The Leaving Certificate Irish Syllabus (revised) (Foundation Level)

As regards the revised syllabus, it is the same syllabus as has been in effect at Foundation Level in recent years. The syllabus has been revised and brought up to date, especially in matters of terminology and range of topics. The teaching and learning of Irish as well as the system of assessment will be governed by the aims and goals of the syllabus as heretofore.

4.2 The Irish Oral Test – from 2012 onwards

The proportiom of marks for the Oral Test will be increased from 150 marks (25% of the overall total of marks) to 240 marks (40% of the overall total of marks). The duration of the Oral Test will be between 8 and 10 minutes, as at present. The same procedure and assessment criteria will be followed. It should be noted however that there will be minor changes in the blocks on which the conversation will be based.
The conversation will be based on these four blocks:
Block 1: The family and the home.
Block 2: School and school matters.
Block 3: Pastimes.
Block 4: Holidays; time and weather; work.

The blocks will be marked out of 50 marks (50 marks x 4 = 200) on ability to communicate, and competence in Irish will be marked out of 40 marks. The effort of the candidate will be assessed from the level excellence to the level very weak as shown below.
Teachers and students are reminded that the examination follows a particular procedure; it is not a simple version of the Higher Level/Ordinary Level examination. The role of the candidate will be secondary.

Table 9

Grade	Class	Irish Repertoire	Ability
A	Excellent	43-50	34-40
B	Very Good	35-42	28-33
C	Good	28-34	22-27
D	Fair	20-27	16-21
E	Weak	13-19	10-15
F	Very Weak	0-10	0-9

4.3 The Aural Comprehension Test – from 2012 onwards

As a result of the reduction in the proportion of marks allotted to the Aural Comprehension Test and the consequent reduction in time, and for the efficient conduct of the examinations, the Aural Comprehension Test will be integrated into the Written Examination (Foundation Level) from 2012 onwards. The paper will begin with the Aural Comprehension Test and the rest of the paper will continue without any interruption. This represents a change from the Aural Comprehension Test being an independent unit of the examination, as heretofore.

The proportion of marks which may be gained on the Aural Comprehension Test will be reduced from 180 marks (30% of the overall total of marks) to 120 marks (20% of the overall total of marks) in the case of Foundation Level. The duration of the listening comprehension examination will be thirty minutes from now on. The examination will follow much the same lines as regards the subject matter and difficulty of the questions. The extent of the subject matter and the number of questions will be reduced in proportion to the reduction in the time. Each item will be played **twice**.

4.4 The Written Paper: 2 hours 20 minutes

It will begin with Aural Comprehension, the duration of which will be 30 minutes. The written paper will consist of two parts, written comprehension and composition. The duration of this part of the examination will be an hour and a half. The Reading Comprehension questions and the Composition question will be in the main as they are at present.

Reading Comprehension: 3 questions

(40 + 50 + 60) = 150/600 marks = 25%

1: Matching: connecting words with 10 pictures (4 marks x 10): 40 marks
2: Two of the following: A Letter/Brochure/News Story (25+25) 50 marks
3: Two of the following: Paragraph/Extract/Poem (30 + 30) 60 marks

Composition: 2 questions

(40 + 50) = 90/600 marks = 15%

1: An announcement ***or*** written reply to an Invitation ***or*** a Letter ***or*** CV: 40 marks
2: A continuous account based on pictures or a store of directive words (c. 90 words) 50 marks

Table 10			
Leaving Certificate: Foundation Level – Paper			
		Time	Marks
1	Listening Comprehension Test	0-30	120
2	Reading Comprehension Written Composition	1-50	150 90
		2-20	**360**

Cluiche Nua Ríomhaireachta: Taitneamh agus Trioblóid